
BBC LEARNING ENGLISH

Job Applications

Understanding job descriptions



This is a transcript of a spoken conversation and is not a word-for-word script.

Phil

From BBC Learning English, this is Learning English for Work and welcome to our special series all about job applications. I'm Phil.

Pippa

And I'm Pippa. In this series, we're talking about every step in the process of getting a job, from search, to interview, to your first day, with helpful vocabulary and tips along the way.

And today, we're talking about how to decide whether a job is right for you.

Phil

You can find a transcript of this episode to read along with on our website: bbclearningenglish.com.

Pippa

OK, so today we're starting with the job search, and specifically job descriptions. So, what's a job description, Phil?

Phil

So, a job description is the information that you get from a company about a job that they're advertising.

Pippa

Right. And this can be quite different depending on the job. So, sometimes it's really detailed and sometimes it is not so detailed. So that makes it a little bit difficult, doesn't it when you're reading a job description?

Phil

Yeah. So, job descriptions are often written in quite formal language. They can use a lot of jargon so it can be difficult to understand exactly what they're trying to say.

Pippa

And because of that, it can be difficult to know from a job description whether you should apply for the job. So, we're going to try and help you with that today.

Phil

Now, throughout this series, we're speaking to Amy Evans, who works in recruitment for the BBC World Service, about how to approach each stage of a job application. And Amy says that job descriptions are usually broken down into two parts.

Amy Evans

Part of it is telling you what the job is, what the sort of overview of that job is. And then daily tasks, overall responsibilities of that job, what you can expect to be doing if you were working in that role.

Pippa

So, part one tells you what the job is so the detail of what a role is like or what you might be expected to do every day.

Amy Evans

And then the other half of it is the company and the hiring manager's opportunity to show what they're looking for in a candidate. And what somebody needs to have in order to do that job.

Phil

So, in this part of the job description, we would expect to see either a list or a paragraph describing what skills they expect you to be able to do or what qualifications they expect you to have.

If you're interested in the job, this is really important to pay attention to.

Amy Evans

If you meet most of the listed criteria needed for the role, and you're able to demonstrate sort of, on an application how you meet that criteria, then I think that's how you know that, you know, you're suitable to apply for the role.

Pippa

Think of it like a checklist. You get a tick if you can do something that the job description is asking for. If the job asks for you to speak Spanish for example, and you can speak Spanish, that's a tick. But it might not always be straightforward. You might not be able to do everything on the list.

Amy Evans

Ideally, obviously, if you can tick off everything that they're looking for, but certainly if you can tick off most of them, and you know that you've got experience in most aspects of what they're looking for, and either you've got that you're currently working in a very similar job or you have a job that might not be the same, but you still do very similar responsibilities, then I think that's how you know that you can sort of put together a strong application as to why you should apply for the one you're looking at.

Phil

And if you do decide to apply for the job, the job description is your most important tool.

Amy Evans

I think it's important the whole way through the process, I would say. Because you can then use that job description to format your application and make sure that you're demonstrating each of the points that they're looking for either in an application form, but also when it then comes to interview.

Phil

Sometimes, job description language is confusing. And that's especially true when it comes to softer skills. Those are the things that you do as part of your job but you don't have a formal qualification for.

Pippa

Yeah so, Phil, shall we have a go at looking at some common soft skills and what they mean?

Phil

OK, yes. So, one of them you might have is **thrive in a fast-paced environment**.

Pippa

Yeah, so if you **thrive in a fast-paced environment**, that means you don't mind being busy, and you don't get too stressed if there's lots to do and lots going on at work.

Phil

And what about if it says **details-orientated**?

Pippa

Yeah so if you're **details-orientated**, that means that you pay attention to the details. And they're looking for somebody who can show that they don't make silly mistakes.

Phil

And then if it says you need **strong problem-solving skills**?

Pippa

So, someone with **strong problem-solving skills** would usually be someone who can think on their own. If something goes wrong at work, they don't panic, they just try and find a solution.

Phil

Now, here's a top tip. Like Amy said, use the job description throughout your application. This is what the company have asked for, so you need to prove you fit into their description.

Pippa

Yeah, don't just read the job description and then throw it away, never look at it again. It's really useful when you're preparing your application and for an interview if you get one.

Phil

That's it for this episode. You can find more business English help on our website: bbclearningenglish.com.

Pippa

Next time, we'll be talking about writing an application and the language you need to stand out to employers.

Phil

See you, then. Bye.

Pippa

Bye.